



"I ALWAYS WANTED TO BE AN INNOVATOR AND CREATE something special, not just be a follower of someone else's idea."

**ATUL KHEKADE,
AIRNETZ AVIATION, 26**

Take your wedding vows mid-air in a chopper, cut your birthday cake while flying over the Arabian Sea or seal that all-important deal in the privacy of your jet. Spending some special moments in a chartered plane has become almost as easy as booking a ticket online. For, Airnetz Aviation can arrange it all for you. Born in 2007, the helicopter and jets charter company is the brainchild of Atul Khekade, an engineer with a dream to "create wealth by innovating on business ideas." Be it business meetings or family holidays, Airnetz has seen over 200 clients and organised 70 flights in the first year of inception.

Khekade, who was on a trip to scout for business opportunities, spotted a fleet of small planes in the hangar of the San Francisco airport in 2005. A quick search on the Internet and he realised that these were private jets owned by the rich and the famous. The concept was new to him but he instantly smelt a lucrative opportunity. With

friend Ritesh Kakkad, he launched Airnetz. "My family didn't encourage entrepreneurship but I always wanted to create something new," says the student of Parle Tilak Vidyalyay, Mumbai. His business mantra was to create a spiralling demand for private aircraft but convincing the city's elite to rent their jets to other customers was no easy task. Today, Airnetz has spread its wings to the US, Europe and Indonesia. The demand, says Khekade, is only set to grow. "People don't know that there are 400 airstrips in India, which are largely used by politicians during campaigns," he says. To popularise his company, he recently launched joyrides for picnickers who can take a 30-minute-long spin in the air for just Rs 1,500.

He is in the business of offering luxury travel to clients but Khekade is not one to spend too much time on luxuries. For the workaholic, free time is all about travelling to new places and exploring business ideas. On a recent holiday to Goa with his wife, he walked to the terminal building instead of taking the bus. He inspected aircraft facilities and chatted with travellers. "I want to explore the world by travelling and talking to people," he says. Confident that his business is set to grow from strength to strength, he has his expansion plans chalked out. "I work less for money and more for a sense of satisfaction and accomplishment," he says with the air of an achiever. The Mumbai boy knows he has many more skies to conquer.

Assessment Plan

Khekade loves spending his day at the airport, chatting with ground staffers and passengers to understand the demands of aviation.

by Aditi Pai